

1.3 Unit 1: People and Politics

What students
need to learn:

Students must learn all topic areas within this unit. There are no optional topics within Unit 1.

Democracy and Political Participation

Key concepts	Content explanation
democracy legitimacy representation direct democracy representative democracy liberal democracy parliamentary democracy political participation referendum	■ Nature of democracy — a knowledge and understanding of the idea of democracy, of the forms that democratic governance has taken, particularly the difference between direct and representative forms of democracy and their strengths and weaknesses, and the nature of liberal democracy. ■ Democracy in the UK — a knowledge and understanding of the main features of democracy in the UK; an awareness of both the strengths of the UK democratic system and why it has been criticised, including reasons for and the extent of the 'participation/legitimacy crisis' in UK politics; how far the UK system conforms to liberal democratic principles; and the implications of developments such as devolution and EU membership. ■ Enhancing democracy — a knowledge and understanding of reforms of the UK democratic system that would extend participation and strengthen accountability, such as the wider use of referendums, lowering the voting age, compulsory voting and digital democracy and an assessment of their implications and possible benefits.

Party Policies and Ideas

Key concepts	Content explanation
political party left/right liberalism conservatism socialism factionalism consensus politics adversary politics	■ Nature of political parties — a knowledge and understanding of political parties, of their distinctive features and of their key functions within the political system. ■ Traditions and policies of parties — a knowledge and understanding of the central ideas, traditions and policies of the major UK political parties, and the development of party policies in recent years and of factors that influence ideological and policy development, including policy and ideological differences within parties. (<i>Although extended questions will not be set solely on political traditions, they may be set on sub-traditions such as 'new' Labour or 'Thatcherism'.</i>) ■ Comparing party policies and ideas — a knowledge and understanding of similarities and contrasts between the ideas and policies of the major parties and of the ideological relationship between and amongst them.

Elections

Key concepts	Content explanation
election majoritarian representation mandate proportional representation electoral reform party system strong government stable government	■ Elections and democracy — a knowledge and understanding of how and why elections promote democracy, and of the limitations of this democratic role. ■ Elections in the UK — a knowledge and understanding of the workings of the voting systems used for elections to the House of Commons, to devolved bodies and local authorities, and to the European Parliament, and an awareness of their implications for party representation and government. ■ Debating electoral systems — a knowledge and understanding of the advantages and disadvantages of the UK electoral systems and, in particular, of the benefits or otherwise of changing the Westminster electoral system. (<i>Extended questions will not be set on particular electoral systems, except for the simple plurality system.</i>)

Pressure Groups

Key concepts	Content explanation
pressure group sectional/ promotional groups insider/outsider groups pluralism elitism functional representation pluralist democracy	■ Nature of pressure groups — a knowledge and understanding of the features and functions of pressure groups; of how and the extent to which they differ from political parties; and an awareness of the different kinds of pressure groups. ■ Pressure group power — a knowledge and understanding of how pressure groups exert influence and of the extent of their influence, and an awareness of the distribution of power amongst pressure groups, including the factors that influence this. ■ Pressure groups and democracy — a knowledge and understanding of the relationship between pressure groups and democracy and, in particular, of the extent to which they promote political participation and responsive government.